

ANI

SHAPING THE FUTURE
Modi interacts with school students on Christmas in New Delhi, Dec. 25

PM's main thrust continues to be to ensure saturation coverage of his welfare schemes and the last-mile delivery, says his principal secretary Pramod K. Mishra

be to ensure good health and fitness for the youth and equip them with appropriate skills. The second is to nurture small and mid-sized businesses and incentivise these enterprises to create high-productivity and high-wage jobs. The third aspect is to prepare the financial sector and capital markets to meet India's investment needs. The PM has made NITI Aayog the nodal point for brainstorming on the goals of Viksit Bharat. CEO Subrahmanyam, who is overseeing the entire exercise, says, "The prime minister believes in the Indian version of exceptionalism. If the Americans believe they are an exceptional country, he believes India's manifest destiny is to be a great country, one with a great heritage and a great future that is not bound by what the rest of the world thinks of us."

The NITI Aayog has formed 10 Sectoral Groups of Secretaries or SGOS to present an action plan to him by the new year. This is the classic Modi style of management—contrary to the Opposition charges of him being authoritarian, he prefers consulting a vast range of experts before deciding on an issue. His cabinet colleagues vouch for him being a patient listener, with an eagle eye for detail and the memory of an elephant. All the meetings Modi convenes are laser-focused, have agendas listed, timelines fixed and the prime minister himself comes well prepared.

Having launched so many schemes and missions, 2023 saw Modi also focus on ensuring that all of them have delivered, in some cases even sending out central officials to the states to check out the progress. Pramod K. Mishra, principal secretary to the prime minister, says, "The PM's main thrust continues to be to ensure saturation coverage of his welfare schemes and also seeing to it that last-mile delivery has taken place. We hold frequent review meetings with all the departments and agencies concerned to monitor progress." This is crucial to Modi's narrative of fulfilling his "guarantees", contrasting his "performance" with the so-called "*parivarvaad*" approach of Opposition parties.

The year 2023 was not just India's moment (as Modi puts it) but truly also the prime minister's. Despite being in the final year of his second term, his personal popularity and credibility remain high. He has redefined the contours of Bharat and rightfully claims that "from a country that earlier used to feel left behind, we have become a country that is leading from the front". Whether it's economic growth, progressive legislation such as women's empowerment, big electoral wins, or his arrival as a global leader, Narendra Modi dominated the headlines and is without doubt India Today's Newsmaker of the Year 2023. ■